eggs, and octopuses can change color. Most of his observations were good—and some were confirmed only centuries later.



An octopus blends in with its surroundings. The ability of these creatures to change color was one of Aristotle's many accurate observations.

The great chain of being

Despite its limitations, Aristotle's method of classification heavily influenced every later attempt at grouping animals and plants until the 18th century. Medieval Christianity developed his *scala naturae* as a "great chain of being," with God at the top of a strict hierarchy, humans and animals beneath, and plants at the bottom.

The Swiss doctor Conrad Gessner wrote the first modern register of animals—also called *History of Animals*—in the mid-16th century. This monumental five-volume work was based on classical sources but included newly discovered species from East Asia. It covered the main animal